

Dargah Quli Khan

Muraqqa' -e- Dehli

THE MUGHAL CAPITAL IN MUHAMMAD
SHAH'S TIME

Foreword

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English Translation with an Introduction and Notes

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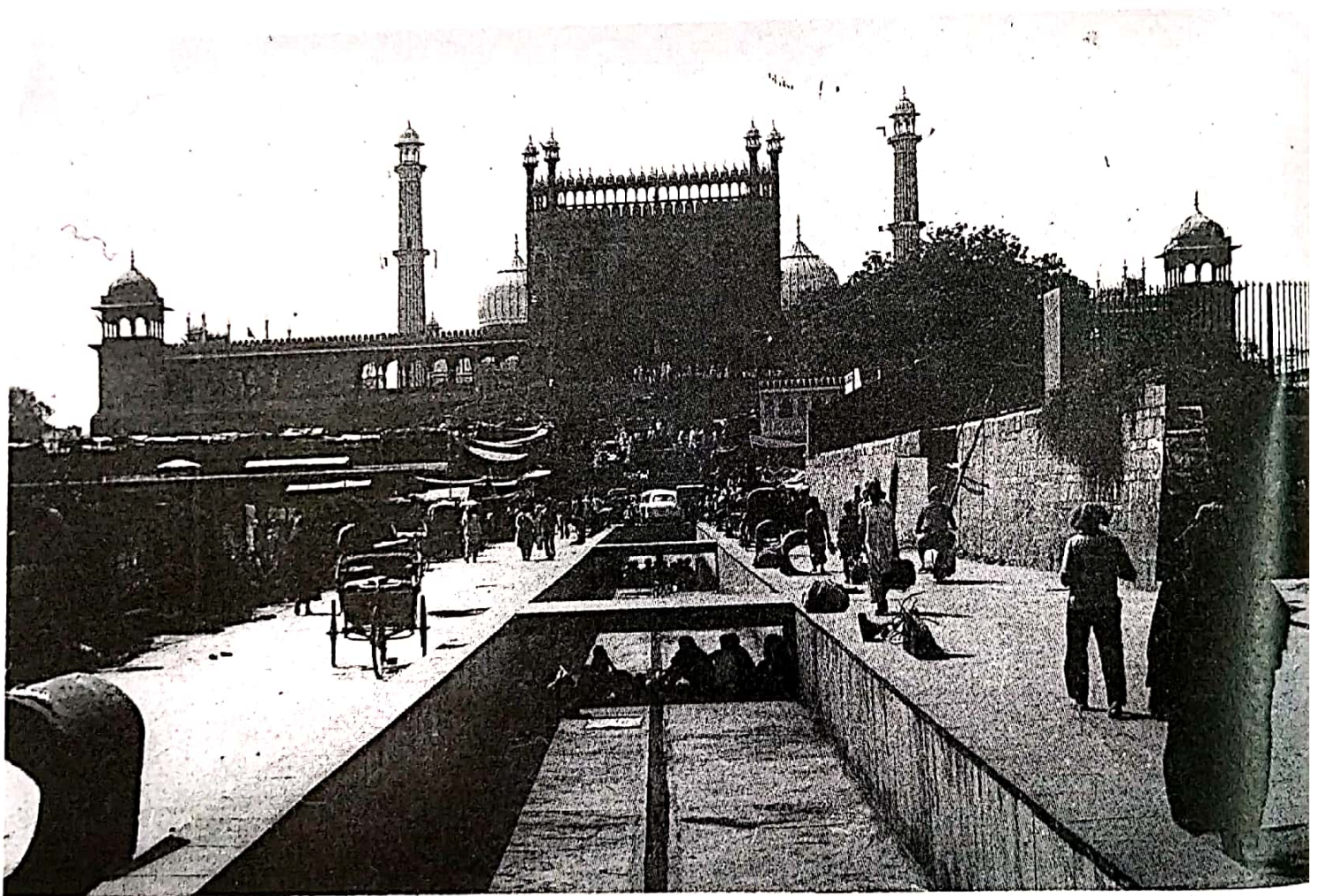
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CHOWK SA'ADULLAH KHAN

The uproar [of the chowk] is in front of the gate of the fort and there is a confluence in the surroundings of the *Peshgah* of the *Jalu-Khana*. Goodness! the varieties of goods that are available would easily make a man loose himself here and the poor eyes would smart at the constant exercise of looking at the abundant display of novelties. There are beautiful lads dancing at intervals and the story tellers playing on the imaginations of the people. Seated on the wooden chairs are fortune tellers reminiscent of the *maulvis* on the pulpits, who speak eloquently on the relative importance of each day and month, the virtues of fasting in the month of *Ramzan-ul-Mubarak*, performance of pilgrimage in the holy month of *Zil-Hijj*, as well as the off-seasonal pilgrimage and narrate the incidents from *Rauzatus-Shohda*² of the month of *Muharram*. The audience give it their full attention. After making the listeners imbibe these details they [fortune tellers] make them part with the money in their pockets. Congregations and aimless folk sit there till long in the night while these sermons go on.

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1. Sa'adullah Khan was a native of Lahore and a renowned noble during the period of Shahjahan and his *Wazir* from 1655 A.D., and remained in that position for a period of twelve years. This market was named after him and was situated from the stairs of the Eastern Gate of the *Jama-Masjid* upto the barbican of the *Dehli Gate* of the Royal Fort. SM, pp. 12-13.
 2. The Garden of Martyrs, the book containing the elegies on the incidents of the *Kerbela* written by Mulla Hussain Kashifi [d. 910 A.H./1504-05 A.D.], a contemporary of Sultan Hussain Mirza Baiqara [1469-1506 A.D.] of Iran. The elegies were recited during the month of *Muharram*. These give an account of the martyrdom of Hazrat Imam Husain and other family members. "A History of Sufism in India", vol. II, p. 22 and "Fahang-e-'Amid", p. 540.

In their respective tents, astrologers and geomancers are occupied with their professions of unfolding the mysteries of the world to the clients. People inquire from them about their good and ill fates and are extremely happy when they are told that good fortune awaits them. Even the doctors and *Hakims*, wearing expensive cloths and conical caps sit on their colourful carpets at their respective places and sell multicoloured pouches which are supposedly a variety of medicines but are in fact just muck. People are made aware of the benefit of these medicines in the manner of one fool befooling the other and there are many fools ahead of others wanting to buy this muck. Tablets, antiseptic lotions, medicinal powder, laxatives and *sherbets* are all available in these shops and whatever else a person wishes to buy. There are medicines which help join bones, cure pimples and arthiritis, rheumatism, and venereal diseases especially Gonorrhea and Bubo, the talk of which generates a lot of excitement. Then, there are special potents to make people virile. People are willing to pawn every thing they own for the sake of these magical cures and the *Hakim*, by the sheer force of his words is able to make them part with their money and hands over to them medicines of membrum virile which will increase their [the buyers] power of sensuality and these cuckolds leave for their houses in a state of euphoria. Large varieties of aromatic compounds are also available. Small fires can be seen burning at intervals and the smoke of *Kushta* [the nine metals] is rising in the sky. Ointments of crab and *sauda*, sand-lizard fat [used as an aphrodisiac] which form a part of an antiseptic cream [can be seen] hanging from threads and is being sold to whosoever requires it. *Naqqals* and flatterers stand at their reserved places entertaining [the people] at the requisite occasions. [This place] is full of catamites and beardless lads. Whenever one raises one's eyes there are beautiful faces and when one extends a hand it rubs across someone's neck.

Arm sellers display a variety of uncovered weapons in order to attract the customers who can gauge their sharpness. The cloth merchants display their wares on their arms making the entire atmosphere colourful and outbidding each other in attracting the customers. Besides this, the eatables are also available. If you extend your hand a morsel is sure to be in your mouth. Dry fruits, both indigenous and imported are being sold, just turn your back and taste them. The market of wild birds and beasts leaves a person gasping. Even the wise are confused by the variety of birds displayed here, and are unable to distinguish them unless they possess sound knowledge about them or have thoroughly studied *Mantiqut-Tair*,³ or have enjoyed the company of Suleman and Asif.⁴ This variety of birds and animals is brought here after ruining many forests and fields. Lovers of wild life, particularly winsome lads, go hunting in large numbers and the experienced hunters reside in the hunting lodges. Colourful and intricately made cages [more beautiful than those in which men reside] are displayed. Thus, the goods of human needs and conspicence are available in this melle of people. At the *Peshgah* of the fort there is a sizeable crowd everyday, through which the nobles and high personages also pass.

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3. An allegorical poem of Muhammad Ibn Fariduddin Attar, one of the most distinguished poet, philosopher and *sufi* of Iran during the period of the *Saljuq* Dynasty.
 4. Son of David who succeeded his father on the throne of Israel in 974 and reigned to 937 B.C. "Encyclopaedia Britainica" Vol. XX p. 951. Asif was a sage considered by the Arabians to have been Suleman's grand *wazir*, hence proverbially used for any wise counsellor. "Steingars", p. 69.

Chandni Chowk¹

Chandi Chowk is the most beautiful and profusely decorated passage in the city. It is a centre of recreation for the pleasure seekers and a gallery of rareties for the interested buyers. Displayed in the shops and ready for sale are varieties of cloth and other goods. The nooks and corners are replete with unique objects procured from different parts of the world. The paths [of the *chowk*] are broad as a wide forehead and bountiful like the blessings of God. The canal² is full of good and clean water and seems as though it is flowing in paradise. Rubies and gems from *Badakhshan* adorn the shops [of the jewellers] and their counters abound with pearls and precious stones. The proprietors sit contentedly on one side of the passage while their subordinates carry out the daily trade. On the other side are cloth merchants beckoning loudly in their sing-song voices to attract the attention of the customers. All day long they carry on a one sided conversation irrespective of whether anyone is interested or not. The *Attars* selling varieties of perfumes and essence carry out a brisk trade with the help of their

1. In front of the Lahauri gate there is a *bazar* measuring 40 yards in width and 1520 yards in length. It was laid out by Jahanara Begum [daughter of Shah Jahan] in 1060 A.H./1650 A.D. There is also a *chowk* 80 yards square at a distance of 480 yards from the Lahauri Gate of the fort. *Kotwali Chabutara* is situated in this *chowk*. An octagonal *chowk* measuring 100×100 yards is also there at a distance of 400 yards from the previous one. This is called *Chandni Chowk*. Beautiful shops are situated around it. MOD, pp. 20-21.
2. Canal was reopened by Ali Mardan Khan in the reign of Shahjahan after he decided to shift the capital of the Mughal Empire from Agra to *Dehli* [*Shahjahanabad*], in 1638 A.D., originally founded by Jalal-ud-Din Firoz Shah Khalji in the year 691 A.H./1291, A.D.



CHANDNI CHOWK

agents and smooth talk. Their perfumes send vapours to the minds of its lovers who come to buy them without any beckoning on the part of the shopkeepers. The heart is completely taken in by the swords, these arched and glistening objects, but one should take care lest the hand is allowed to slip on the sharp blade. On beholding these snake like daggers one wishes the enemy were close for attack and it is better to keep some distance from them. All the self control one imposes here on oneself melts away at the sight of the China crockery and a variety of colourful and gilded *huqqas* of glass. Bowls, jugs and exquisite wine cups are displayed in the shops which attract even the aged pious to savour a drink. Men can be found standing on the roads selling such a range of choicest clothing that the wares of the shopkeepers are dull by comparison. Perhaps even the houses of the nobility do not have such things. Besides, in the evening when the sun spreads its rosy hue, the vivid and the kaleidoscopic scene which meets the eye is not to be found even while strolling in the gardens.

Around the *chowk* are many *Qahwa khana*³ where eloquent poets are to be found reciting their verses and eliciting praise from those present. The nobles, irrespective of their status are unable to suppress their desire of taking a stroll here. The assortment of rare and unique goods available in this market cannot be bought at one time even if the treasury of *Qarun*⁴ was at one's disposal.

A son of a [deceased] nobleman wanted to stroll in this *chowk*. His mother, convincing him of her inability [to give more money] handed him an amount of a lakh of rupees from the wealth left behind by his father. [She said] that rare things cannot be purchased from this *chowk* for this small sum, but, however as he is inclined to go there, some essential items of his choice can be obtained.

3. Coffee House.

4. Name of the son of Moses' paternal uncle, the Korah of the Old Testament, and proverbial for his wealth. "Steingars", p. 947.